

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD XRed 1/29/01 wpl**Species:** Tri-colored Heron (*Egretta tricolor*)**Date:** 24 July 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** unknown**Plumage:** Adult**Locality:** Russell Lakes SWA**Elevation:** 7800 ft.**Nearest town:** Saguache**County:** Saguache**Time observed:** about 1115-1120 MDT**Duration of observation:** about 30 seconds in three views

Description: While conducting special species colony counts for the Colorado Bird Observatory, Rich Levad and I observed an adult Tri-colored Heron in a marsh behind the Russell Lakes State Wildlife Area maintenance facilities. The bird had the typical heron look of long legs, elongated body, and long, pointed bill and, standing in close proximity with adult Snowy Egrets (*Egretta thula*), was only slightly bigger-bodied and taller than them by a few inches. It spooked easily and we flushed the bird three times, once yielding an unobstructed side view showing the distinctive 3-colored pattern for Tri-colored Heron [blue-gray back, rust-colored neck (a white throat extending the length of the neck and connecting with the belly was noticed on the bird when it was initially seen standing with the egrets), and white belly]. Because of the quick view and focusing on feather coloration and pattern, I did not notice exact leg or bill color, but both appeared dark. In flight going directly away from us, the upperparts were entirely blue-gray, lacking the contrasting darker flight feathers of Great Blue Heron (*Ardea herodias*).

Separation from similar species: No other heron species has the combination of rust-colored neck, white belly, and blue-gray upperparts.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): I heard none.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen dozens of Tri-colored Herons while living and/or birding along the Gulf coast from Florida to Texas.

Light conditions: sun above and to my right, clear sky

Optical equipment used: Zeiss 7x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at 70 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Rich Levad (also saw the bird days earlier)

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Dean and Larry (CDOW employees at Russell Lakes SWA). I believe Dean may be the original observer. I don't know their last names.

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Doug Faulkner

Signature:

Doug Faulkner

Address: Rocky Mountain Bird Observatory, 14500 Lark Bunting Lane, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: This report was written on 30 July 2000 from memory.